ruled his empire. Although he continued to wage war to expand his empire, he also greatly increased his focus on what we would now call governance. He worked to improve the lot of his subjects and also tried hard to find a solution to the grievances that arose from the conflicting religious views within the empire. He established religious and philosophical discussions as soon as he returned to his capital in Fatehpur Sikri in a hall called the ibadat khana (house of worship) in which religious thinkers were invited to participate in discussions and debates. Akbar invited Sunnis and Shias, Hindus, Christians, Jains, millennial Mahdavis, and many others, to what was perhaps the world's first site of interfaith debates on such a large scale. Akbar's astonishing conclusions from these fevered and sometimes furious discussions was that blind superstitions and irrational beliefs led to violence, and that all beliefs should be gauged through the pure lens of reason. He urged people to learn about others' religions, so as to dispel intolerant prejudices against each other and develop, instead, a sense of empathy. This, Akbar was convinced, would lead to a spirit of universal peace and active tolerance, which he called sulh kul. All religions, he believed, were either equally true or equally untrue and so deserved equal respect and protection.

Today, in a world fatally fractured along religious lines, it seems inconceivable that in the sixteenth century an emperor worked so hard to promote religious harmony and reverence for all faiths. This atmosphere of easy-going acceptance of a variety of faiths, customs, and beliefs in Mughal Hindustan under Akbar was quite opposed to the violent intolerance of neighbouring Safavid Persia or, indeed, the raging religious wars in Europe. As Persia in the late sixteenth century began to persecute all non-Shiite factions including Sunnis and Sufis, the subcontinent was seen as a land of capacious acceptance.

Akbar kept himself closely informed of happenings overseas and was curious about other countries and monarchies and sent embassies to the Safavid and Uzbek monarchs, to the Portuguese at Goa, and even contemplated sending an embassy to Philippe II of Spain and Portugal. This curiosity remained a keystone of Akbar's character, and it allowed him to continuously seek innovative solutions to the world around him. Apart from the many improvements he made to muskets, rockets, and other military technology, Akbar was also a pioneer in ship-building, construction methods, metallurgy, alchemy, and a great deal more. The Mughal Empire